Small, dark green, and with a distinctive earthy flavor, puy lentils are less floury than paler or red lentils, and they cook quickly without disintegrating.

puy lentil soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS AT THE END OF STEP 2

3 tbsp fruity olive oil, plus extra for serving
1 Spanish onion, finely chopped
1 garlic clove, crushed
14oz (400g) puy lentils, rinsed and drained
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 thick ham steaks, about 3½oz (100g) each
2 sprigs of fresh thyme
2 sprigs of flat leaf parsley
1 tbsp finely chopped parsley, to serve
1 tsp grated zest of an unwaxed lemon, to serve

1 Put 1½ tbsp oil in a large, heavy saucepan over medium heat. Cook the onion and garlic for 2–3 minutes until golden and softened, stirring frequently. Stir in the lentils and season with salt and pepper. Put one of the ham steaks on top of the lentils and add the thyme and parsley. Pour in enough cold water to cover the lentils and ham with an extra 1¼in (3cm) water on top. Bring gently to a simmer, partially cover, and cook for 25–30 minutes until the lentils are cooked through.

2 Lift out the cooked ham steak and chop into small pieces. Discard the parsley and thyme. Reserving 3 ladlefuls of soup, put the contents of the pan with the chopped ham in a blender or food processor and process until smooth. Return to the pan and stir in the reserved mixture.

3 Gently reheat until piping hot. Meanwhile, using the rest of the oil, cook the second ham steak in a nonstick frying pan over medium-high heat for 4–5 minutes, turning after 3 minutes, until cooked through and crisp and golden on both sides. Cut into small chunky pieces.

4 Taste and adjust the seasoning. Stir the soup and ladle into warmed bowls. Scatter the crispy ham over the top and add a drizzle of extra virgin olive oil. Finish with a little chopped parsley and lemon zest, mixed together, and serve.